The First-Time Manager - Study guide

Practitioner course | Trainer: Daniel Okafor

About this guide

The conversations, habits and boundaries that make the first year of managing work.

These notes follow the video lecture for this course. Read them before or after watching, and use them to revise before the final quiz.

What you will be able to do

- Run one-to-ones people find useful

- Delegate without disappearing

- Give feedback that changes behaviour

The shift from doing to leading

- Your job is now other people’s results

- Your attention is the scarce resource

- Let go of the right things first

Welcome to The First-Time Manager. The biggest change in your first year is not a new title, it is a new job. You used to be measured on your own work. Now you are measured on what your team achieves. That shift is mostly about where you spend your attention. Many new managers keep doing the work they were good at, because it feels safe, and then have no time left to lead. In this lecture we cover one to ones, delegation and feedback, which are the three habits that make the first year work.

What to let go of first

- Tasks others can learn to do

- The need to be the expert

- Being available for everything

Letting go is hard because the tasks you drop are often the ones you do best. Start with work that someone else can learn, even if they will do it slower at first. Let go of needing to be the expert in the room, because your value now is helping others do well. And let go of being available for every question, since constant interruptions

teach people to depend on you. A useful test is to ask whether a task needs you specifically, or just needs to get done. If it is the second, it is a candidate for handing over.

One to ones that matter

- Weekly, short, and about them

- Start with their agenda

- Surface problems early

A good one to one is the most useful management tool you have. Keep it weekly and keep it regular, even when it is short. Make it about the other person, not a status update for you. Start by asking what they would like to talk about, then cover what is blocking them, what they are proud of, and what support they need. The aim is to surface problems early, while they are still small. If you cancel one to ones when you are busy, people learn that they come second, and they stop bringing you the early warnings.

A simple one to one structure

- Check in as a person

- Their topics, then yours

- Agree actions and write them down

Here is a structure you can use straight away. Begin with a short check in, how are things, really. Then cover their topics first, followed by yours. Ask open questions such as, what would make this week easier. Before you finish, agree on actions, who will do what by when, and write them down so you can start the next meeting by reviewing them. Keep notes brief and keep them private. Over a few weeks the pattern builds trust, because people can see that what they say leads to something happening.

Delegation without disappearing

- Match support to the person and the task

- Share the outcome and the why

- Agree check-ins before you hand over

Delegation does not mean throwing a task over the wall. Match the level of support to the person and the task. Someone new to a task needs more guidance than someone who has done it five times. Share the outcome you want and the reason it matters, not only the steps. And agree check-ins before you hand anything over, so that you stay informed without hovering. Delegating and disappearing leaves people stuck. Delegating and hovering takes the ownership back. The middle path is clear expectations, agreed checkpoints, and trust between them.

Feedback that lands

- Describe the behaviour

- Explain its impact

- Say what you would like instead, then listen

Feedback works best when it is specific and timely. Describe the behaviour you saw, without judging the person. Explain the impact it had on the team or the result. Say what you would like to see instead. Then stop talking and listen, because the other person may know something you do not. Give positive feedback with the same care, since people repeat what they are told works. Do not save feedback for the annual review. A small comment given the same week is easier to hear and easier to act on than a large one given months later.

Common mistakes in the first year

- Avoiding the hard conversation

- Treating everyone the same way

- Forgetting to ask for feedback yourself

Three mistakes appear again and again. The first is avoiding the hard conversation, hoping it will fix itself. It rarely does, and the problem usually grows. The second is treating everyone the same, when people need different levels of support and different ways of hearing feedback. The third is forgetting to ask for feedback yourself. Ask your team what you could do differently, and then actually do something with the answer. Being willing to hear it models the behaviour you want from them, and

it shows you are still learning too.

Your next steps

- Book your next three one to ones

- Choose one task to delegate this week

- Complete the workbook and the final quiz

To finish, put your next three one to ones in the diary now. Choose one task you will delegate this week, and write down the outcome, the reason, and the check in date. Complete the workbook for this course, which has templates for each habit. Then take the final quiz. When you reach the end of the last lesson you will receive your certificate and a personal review of how you completed the course. The first year is demanding, so be patient with yourself, and keep practising these three habits.

Glossary

One to one: A regular private meeting between a manager and a team member, centred on the team member.

Delegation: Handing over a task with clear expectations, support and agreed check-ins.

Feedback: Specific information about behaviour and its impact, with a suggestion for what to do instead.

Check-in: A planned point at which you review progress on delegated work.